

For any given budget, there will always be a particular set of features that you, as an informed user, will be looking at. Some of you might have a slightly flexible budget (we're talking upwardly-flexible here). We've provided you with a look at all the camera features together—subdivided under the price headings of course.

FEATURES Entry-Level Cameras

People buying within this category are mostly value-conscious users, and those making a first foray into the realm of digital photography. The term Casual Clicker comes to mind.

We received nine cameras in this category, spanning five vendors—Sony, Techcom, Nikon, Olympus, and Premier.

We'll give the award for the "best-looking sub-8,500 camera" to the Premier DC6370 and DC5370 duo, since their look garnered the most votes in our test labs. A hairs-breadth behind in second place is the Techcom DSC 512-X Plus. The Nikon L4 looked rather plain and even the Sony S-40 was quite a disappointment as far as looks go—rather bland.

With looks out of the way, it was time we looked at durability. Both the above-mentioned Premier models also had good build quality. Techcom gets to pole position for the DSC 524-X Plus: great build quality, feels solid in the hand. The Premier DC6370 and DC5370 finished a close second.

We weren't too surprised at none of the bigger guns like Sony, Nikon or Olympus getting kudos for build quality, simply because they are pricier; to get to their better-built models, you need to shell out more!

Let's get to the two stragglers as far as quality-of-build goes: the Premier DS5082 was abysmally lacking, especially when compared to its cheaper cousin, the DS 3088S, which at Rs 3,850 broke all price barriers as far as we know. The DS 3088S even has metal adorning some parts of its body, while the DS 5082 feels "plasticity". Both these models from Premier feature sliders that conceal the lens which is a sore point, because, the less the number of moving parts in a camera the lesser are its chances of being damaged due to regular usage. However, since both these models are cheaper than the other cameras in this category, we shall refrain from being too condescending.

The cameras in this segment costing less shouldn't necessarily equate to a nose-dive on the features count. And in fact, we were pleasantly surprised at the number of features thrown aboard by cameras available in the



TechCom 524-X PLUS

We liked those suave dark looks, but the sticker looks gaudy, though

market today. Last time we conducted such a test, the "budget" price bracket was kept at Rs 10,000. Even that has fallen!

It's hard to ignore the on-paper specs of the DC6370. Premier has done their homework well, and once again the issue of price rears its head—you get a lot of features here for Rs 7,500. A 2.4 inch, 1,15,000 pixel screen ensures you see all the action without squinting, while the 6-megapixel CCD ensures you'll also be able to capture that on-screen action for fun viewing later! The Nikon L4 sported a crisp two inch TFT (thin film transistor) display, that was the clearest among all except the Sony S40, which was half an inch smaller. The Nikon L4 is also very newbie friendly—no ISO settings, just an 'Auto' mode. The Techcom 524-X has a decent menu layout—it's very simple and intuitive.

The Techcom cameras were the only models here to feature inbuilt games. This sounds weird: games on a digital camera? Well, the feature is there, and you decide whether it's a value-add or not! Incidentally, the Techcom and Premier models don't come with manual viewfinders, so you'll be using the LCD viewfinder all the time. You should know that using the LCD adversely affects battery life, as compared to the plain old viewfinder.

The Premier DS-3088S warrants mention as well, though for the wrong reasons. It's really feature-shy: no optical zoom, no autofocus, and a depressing LCD. Following its cheaper brother faithfully is the DS-5082: a slightly better LCD, but missing many essential features.



Nikon L4

Feature rich performer that needs a body makeover!

Mid-Range Cameras

Any camera falling in this category has a tough task ahead of it when it comes to proving its mettle. It has to be feature-rich enough to justify the higher price, and should also perform accordingly. Those buying within this segment also tend to be more discerning than the folk in the first segment, and they also value each and every goodie (read neat feature) they are getting—even if they aren't as informed as those falling in the third category.

This was the most sparsely-populated price segment, with just six cameras. The Sony W50 is